Mid-Term Exam Outline for DH 2126-Phil 2078 – Fall 2026

Exam Details

When: Open from 9:00 a.m. Wednesday, October 28th until 11:55 p.m. EST on Tuesday, November 3rd, 2026.
Where: Brightspace.
Duration: 4 hours.
Format: Descriptive Essays.
Value: 20% of final grade.

This exam will require you to write **6 descriptive** essay answers (approximately 200 – 400 words per answer, with an **absolute limit of 700 words**… anything over 700 words will be disregarded) worth **10 marks each**, for a total of **60 marks**.

NOTE: YOU MUST WRITE IN FULL SENTENCES… NO POINT FORM.

ALSO NOTE: The fact that each question is worth 10 marks is not intended to indicate anything about how many points you are expected to include (i.e., you won't have to clearly explain 10 separate points for each question). Rather, it's a means by which consistency in the grading can be secured (I'll be saying more about the grading below).

Proctortrack

Proctortrack will be used on this exam (and on the final exam). That means that you'll need to use a computer with the capacity to run the software (tablets and phones cannot run Proctortrack), a functioning webcam, and a stable/reliable internet connection.

The primary reason for using Proctortrack is to maintain the integrity of the exam to ensure that it's fair for everyone… that means, in part, ensuring that you are the one who is writing your exam, that you aren't receiving help from someone else while you are writing, and that you aren't using Generative AI to formulate your answers.

The exam will, however, be **OPEN-BOOK**; you will have access to the readings, your own notes, and my videos while you write.

NOTE: You will have to enter the exam through the Proctortrack link that will appear under the 'Content' tab on Brightspace… you **cannot** enter the exam from the 'Quizzes' area on Brightspace.

ALSO NOTE: If you've written an exam using Proctortrack previously, you'll have to uninstall the older version from your computer, and download/reinstall the new version.

Material Covered and Distribution

Here's an explicit list of exactly which readings will be covered in which question of the exam.

Question #1: Will ask you about both the Douglas and Westerstrand readings (from Week 2).
Question #2: Will ask you about both the Muller-Salo and Austin readings (from Week 3).
Question #3: Will ask you about both the Schechtman and Bortolan readings (from Week 4).
Question #4: Will ask you about both the Wolfendale and Lundgren readings (from Week 5).
Question #5: Will ask you about both the Matthews reading (from Week 2) and the Frost-Arnold (from Week 6) readings.
Question #6: Will ask you about both the O'Neill and Levy readings (from Week 6).

NOTE: The questions are **focused on the readings**, **NOT MY VIDEO LECTURES**. My video lectures are intended to help you understand the readings, but the readings are the primary object of focus for your studying. So the better you understand the readings (helped by my video lectures), the better your expected result should be.

Time to completion

The exam will be **TIMED**. Specifically, you will have **4 hours** in which to complete the exam once you have started.

Time is not really supposed to be a factor for this exam. But keep in mind that the time limit means that you will not be able to learn the material while you're taking the exam. It is open-book/open-video, but that material should just be a fail-safe if you're struggling to remember a detail from one of the readings.

NOTE: Once you've started the exam, **THE TIMER BEGINS**. That means that as soon as you start it, the 4 hours starts counting down… the timer **DOES NOT STOP** if you log out of Brightspace. Once the 4 hours are over, your exam is done.

Goals and Assessment

The purpose of this exam is to assess **your understanding** of the readings that we're engaging (as explained/expanded upon in my video lectures). That means (at least) two things:

i. The questions will be **PURELY DESCRIPTIVE**. In other words, the questions will **NOT** ask you to **assess/make an argument about** the readings (i.e., to provide reasons for thinking there's something wrong with the view a particular author defends). Assessment/making an argument occurs in your essays… here, the goal is to merely test your knowledge/understanding of the arguments each author presents.

ii. The best answers (those that receive full marks) will be those which demonstrate a **clear and accurate understanding** of the material.

THIS MEANS THAT YOU CANNOT ANSWER (and receive full grades) BY MERELY QUOTING FROM THE ARTICLE OR MY VIDEOS!!!!

In other words, merely copying your answers from either the text of the reading or my video **does not show that you understand** the element of the reading about which you are being asked. Doing so will therefore cause you to lose grades.

NOTE: The **highest grade** you will be eligible to receive should you choose to copy the lecture notes or passages from the readings **is 4.5/10** (and you'll receive 4.5/10 only if you copied and pasted the exactly right passages from my videos or the readings).

ALSO NOTE: Paraphrasing is necessary to demonstrate your understanding of the material. But paraphrasing **DOES NOT** consist in merely copying my note or the reading and then simply changing a couple of the key words. You're going to have to express the ideas/arguments presented in the readings in your own terms (with the exception of technical language an author relies upon).

FINAL NOTE: Even though paraphrasing is necessary, you will also have to rely on the key/central terms from the readings. Part of assessing your comprehension of the readings will involve you being able to recognize which terms/phrases are essential to an author's position, and which are able to be replaced by synonyms.

REMEMBER: The ultimate goal of your answer is to demonstrate that you understand the relevant ideas/concepts/arguments about which you are being asked, such you can accurately and completely explain them to someone else.

Structure of the Questions and your Answers

As far as structuring your answers goes, try to **follow the structure of the question**…

As you'll see, **the questions are made up of several sentences**, so you might think of **each sentence as needing a paragraph or two (or three) to respond**.

But this is just a guideline. Not every sentence of every question will require an entire paragraph (sometimes your response to some portion of the question could be as short as a few words), so you'll need to **use your judgment**.

Here's an example (that obviously won't appear on your exam, and for that matter, is not actually relevant to our course) that should help clarify what I mean:

What is Descartes's view of 'substance'? What are the reasons he provides in support of that view? How does Descartes's account of substance affect his view of animals?

So, this question is **identical in structure** to those that will appear on your exam (but is shorter than those you'll have, and it only asks about one author's view, rather than the two about which you'll be asked in each question).

The first sentence would probably not merit an entire paragraph… you could simply state that he maintains there are two substances in the universe, extended things and thinking things, followed by his definitions of 'extended' and 'thinking' things.

Then you would provide an account of Descartes' argument in favour of the view that there are only two substances. This might actually take more than a paragraph, **depending on how many steps (i.e., premises) are involved in the argument**, and **how many details you include to elaborate each step**.

Finally, you would end your answer with a new paragraph which details how that argument influences Descartes' view of animals, which again, could take more than a single paragraph depending on your judgment.

The point is that you should **use the structure of the question to guide the structure of your answer.**

NOTE: Since your answers to these questions are not 'essays' (i.e., you're not defending a thesis by presenting your own reasons), you should **JUST ANSWER THE QUESTION!!! DO NOT INCLUDE AN INTRODUCTION OR CONCLUSION IN YOUR ANSWERS!!!!**

AGAIN: NO INTRODUCTIONS, NO CONCLUSIONS… JUST ANSWER THE QUESTION!!!

ALSO NOTE: As far as the specifics of your answer are concerned, **the philosophical virtues of being clear and precise hold for exams**. You must answer the question directly and completely, i.e., don't include irrelevant points that fail to directly answer the question you're being asked, and make sure you don't leave anything out.

Grading

As I noted above, each of your answers will receive a grade out of 10. The most refined grade you will receive is a 0.5, i.e., the grading increments will proceed by half a mark (so 5/10, 5.5/10, 6/10, 6.5/10, 7/10, 7.5/10, etc…).

If you **accurately** answer **every** element of the question that you've been asked, but then fail to include any of the details elaborating your answer, you will receive a minimum of 7/10.

The difference between answers that receive a 7/10 and those that receive 10/10 will therefore be a difference of degree, one that is based on the extent to which you accurately and precisely articulate the details relevant to that answer.

For an answer to get less than 7/10, the answer has either failed to respond to each element of the question, and/or has inaccurately answered the question.

NOTE: Each question on the exam will be graded by a single T.A. (or me) for all 366 students in the course (one of the nicer features of Brightspace's 'Quizzes' function). Doing so ensures that there will be a consistency across the entire class in the grading of each question.

Study Tip

I only have one real study tip, and it might seem obvious, but after my online teaching experiences over the course of these past two years, it's a point that is not as obvious to some as I thought it would/should be. Here's the tip:

PREPARE FOR THE EXAM AS THOUGH YOU ARE WRITING IT IN PERSON!!!!!

While I believe that many students recognize this point, a surprisingly large number don't appear to. I take it that the explanation is the fact that it's an open-book exam. That is, there's a possible four hours of writing time, and the exam is open-book (and 'open video lecture'), leading some students to believe that they'll be able to learn the details about the readings the questions ask about while the exam is taking place. **THIS IS** (I humbly submit) **A MISTAKEN BELIEF**!!!!

Those who write the best answers (again, I think/suspect… I don't have any data to back me up) are those who **DON'T HAVE TO LOOK UP THE ANSWER TO A QUESTION BEFORE STARTING TO COMPOSE THEIR RESPONSE,**

BECAUSE THEY KNOW THE ANSWER AS SOON AS THEY READ THE QUESTION.

The idea is that if you've prepared such that you know the answer as soon as you read the question, you'll be able to make efficient use of the ample time you're likely to have… once you've written all your answers, you'll have time to reread and edit them. That is, you'll be able make your answers more precise, and ensure all the relevant details have been included.

If you've got any questions about anything I've said in this document, don't hesitate to come by my Zoom office hours on Wednesdays from 4:30 – 6:30 p.m., or post a question for me in the 'Questions for Ryan' discussion forum.